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A Phoenician Inscription from 'Akko*

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DURING the seventh season of excavations at Tel 'Akko in 1980, a Phoenician inscription written on a rim and body fragment of a pottery bowl was discovered.¹ This inscription immediately aroused special attention, for its length (seven lines) is considerably greater than that of other Phoenician inscriptions found to date at 'Akko, which consist only of single words or several letters. The inscription is, moreover, the longest Phoenician cursive inscription yet found in Israel.²

Before proposing a reading and translation of the inscription, it is necessary to describe the exact provenance of the ostrakon and the circumstances surrounding its

* Published in slightly different form in Hebrew in *EI* 18 (1985), pp. 116–123, Pl. 23.

I wish to express my sincere thanks to friends and colleagues with whom I discussed this inscription and who advised me on its reading and interpretation: Profs. N. Avigad, J.C. Greenfield, B. Mazar and J. Naveh of the Hebrew University, Jerusalem; Prof. M. Heltzer of the University of Haifa; E. Puech of the Ecole biblique et archéologique, Jerusalem; and Prof. A. Millard of the University of Liverpool. Special thanks are due to Profs. F.M. Cross of Harvard University and B. Peckham of the University of Toronto, with whom I discussed mainly the paleographical problems of the inscription. I am most grateful to the photographic laboratory of the Israel Police Headquarters for the fine infra-red photographs of the ostrakon that appear here.

The following abbreviations are used in this paper: *DISO* — C.F. Jean and J. Hoftijzer: *Dictionnaire des inscriptions sémitiques de l'Ouest*, Leiden, 1965; *KAI* — H. Donner and W. Röllig: *Kanaanäische und aramäische Inschriften*, I–II, Wiesbaden, 1962–1964; *Kition* III — M.G. Guzzo-Amadasi and V. Karageorghis: *Fouilles de Kition*, III: *Inscriptions phéniciennes*, Nicosia, 1977; Lidzbarski — M. Lidzbarski: *Phönizische und aramäische Krugaufschriften aus Elephantine*, Berlin, 1912; Vanel — A. Vanel: Six 'ostraca' phénicienne trouvés au temple d'Echmoun, près de Saïda, *Bulletin du Musée de Beyrouth* 20 (1967), pp. 45–95.

¹ M. Dothan: 'Akko, 1980 (Notes and News), *IEJ* 31 (1981), pp. 110–112.

² The eleven-line inscription from Kh. el-Ma'shub, a site near Kibbutz Mašuva, about 15 km. north of 'Akko, is written on stone. Its provenance is probably Umm el-'Amed in southern Lebanon; see *CIS* I, No. 7; *KAI*, No. 19; J.B. Peckham: *Development of Late Phoenician Scripts*, Cambridge, Mass., 1968, p. 76. The Phoenician ostrakon found at Tell el-Kheleifeh, though it has eight lines, comprises a maximum of ten words and is therefore much shorter than the 'Akko inscription; N. Glueck: Tell el-Kheleifeh Inscriptions, in H. Goedicke (ed.): *Near Eastern Studies in Honor of W.F. Albright*, Baltimore, 1971, pp. 229–231; see also J. Naveh: The Scripts of Two Ostraca from Elath, *BASOR* 183 (1966), pp. 27–28.

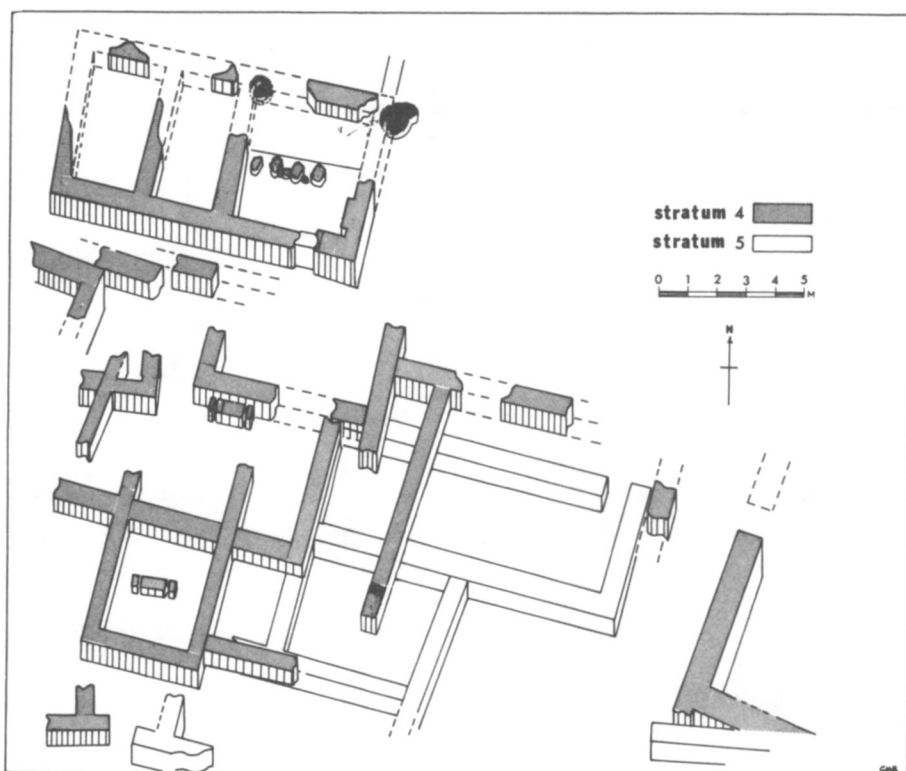


Fig. 1. Isometric view of Area A in the Persian period, Strata 4–5. The building in which the ostrakon was found is on the upper left.

discovery. It was found in the northern section of the mound (Area A) in a stratum which lies above the remains of the early *terre pisée* rampart (Fig. 1). The remains of the buildings found in this area in the 1980 season date mainly from the Persian and Hellenistic periods. Most of the Hellenistic buildings were found in a poor state of preservation, owing primarily to cultivation of the surface of the mound in the nineteenth century.

Several buildings of the Persian period (c. 530–330 B.C.E.) were better preserved, and it is possible at least in part to reconstruct their plans. Reconstruction of these buildings is aided by the plans of adjacent Persian period structures discovered in previous seasons of excavation.³ The foundations of large Persian period buildings oriented north-east–south-west were found; among them, the remains of a probably once imposing structure are of special interest. Sections of thick perpendicular walls and their corner joint were traced. These walls are partly of solid Phoenician construction in header-stretcher style. The finds from this area, in addition to the common pottery of the period, included small objects such as figurines.

³ M. Dothan: Akko: Interim Report, First Season, 1973/4, *BASOR* 224 (1976), pp. 26–29.

North of this complex, foundations of a three-room structure were uncovered in the 1980 season, sections of which were also constructed in the Phoenician header-stretcher style. To the south of this structure, an alley apparently leading to the large building mentioned above was discovered.

In the easternmost room of the structure were four bases of columns which seem to have served a dual purpose: to support the ceiling and to divide the room into a roofed section and an open courtyard. Two superimposed floors were found in this room and large amounts of Persian period pottery were associated with both levels. Both floors were partly damaged and a section of one wall was disturbed in antiquity. The ensuing robber's trench was filled with dirt and debris, including many sherds from the Persian period. It is as yet impossible to determine whether this material accumulated over an extended period, with the debris from the Persian period floor levels gradually filling the robber's trench, or whether the pit was intentionally filled with this debris in the Hellenistic period. Among the sherds in this debris, almost all of which are from the Persian period, two ostraca were found. One of them bore a series of numbers with connecting *waws*. The second bore the seven-line inscription which is the subject of this paper.

The inscription is written on both sides of a discarded late Iron Age II sherd (Pl. 13:A–B). It was drawn in black ink over the reddish, unevenly applied slip. The first four lines are on the outside of the sherd; the three remaining lines continue on the inside. A margin is left on the right side of the inscription on both the outside and the inside of the sherd. The slip has peeled off in several places, removing parts of some letters. In other cases the ink has splashed or peeled off, leaving the reading of a few letters open to different interpretations.⁴

The inscription reads:

1	בדת לבנ חרש אש יתנ אגנ כ
2	בד לשלת אש על אשרת גלנמ
3	1 וממלאמ ז"ו"ו" ופכש
4	ת אדרת זזזז ולפמ
5	זזז ולגממ זזז
6	מלפחת זזז זז זז זז
7	זז זז זז זז זז זז זז

- 1 By order: to the guild of (metal?) artisans; they shall give a valuable basin
- 2 to שלת, the overseer of the shrine(s); (likewise they shall give) metal cups (golden?)
- 3 10, and vessels with inlay (round ringstands?) 25, and large
- 4 pyxides 70, and pots (on stands)
- 5 60, and decanters 60, and
- 6 smiths' blown vessels 57
- 7 and small deep bowls 30.

⁴ These letters are indicated below in the paleographical commentary.

COMMENTARY

Line 1. בדת. The reading of *bet* and *taw* is certain, though *dalet* might be challenged (see however below, p. 88). דת in the meaning of 'law, command, order' was absorbed into Hebrew, Aramaic and Neo-Babylonian from Persian.⁵ In Phoenician inscriptions it appears only once, in the tariff inscription from Kition.⁶ Though the *dalet* there is not absolutely certain, most scholars now agree on the reading דת.⁷ It would thus seem possible, because of the reading בדת in our inscription, to restore the first, damaged letter of the Kition inscription as *bet*, resulting in בדת. Such a restoration is more likely than the proposed restorations of עדת or מדת.⁸ In our inscription the meaning of בדת, 'by order, according to the law', seems to be most acceptable.

לבנ חרש. The preposition ל- seems to be in the meaning 'for, to'. Apparently we should read in the plural בני חרש, meaning members of an artisans' guild, most probably metal-workers. If בנ in the singular were intended, a personal name would have preceded the profession. Although the personal name בנחרש is found, mainly in late texts, this does not seem to be the case here.⁹

⁵ דת appears in the Bible several times; in Hebrew in the book of Esther and in Aramaic in the books of Ezra and Daniel. דת certainly meant law, as in Dan. 6:15 (MT 6:16), דת למדי ופרס, 'the law of the Medes and Persians'. Twice the preposition ב- is prefixed to דת; בדת אלהך, 'according to the law of thy God' (Ezra 7:14) and בדת אלהה, 'concerning the law of his god' (Dan. 6:5; MT 6:6). Once ב- is the preposition of the plural, בדתי פרס ומדי, 'by the laws of the Persians and the Medes' (Est. 1:19). It should be noted that the preposition ב- in Hebrew is also used with words close to דת in meaning, such as מצוה, 'commandment' (2 Chron. 24:21; Neh. 12:24). For the use of ב- in Phoenician as an instrumental or functional preposition, see S. Segert: *A Grammar of Phoenician and Punic*, Munich, 1976, p. 208. For the occurrence of the Persian loan word *dāšnā* in an Aramaic inscription from the fourth century B.C.E., see F.M. Cross: An Ostrakon from Nebi Yunis, *IEJ* 14 (1964), p. 186.

⁶ The Kition inscription, first published in *CIS* I, No. 86A-B in 1881, has been republished and discussed many times during recent years. Among the latest thorough treatments of the subject are J.B. Peckham: Notes on a Fifth-Century Inscription from Kition, Cyprus (*CIS* 86), *Orientalia* 37 (1968), pp. 304–324; J.P. Healey: The Kition Tariffs and the Phoenician Cursive Series, *BASOR* 216 (1974), pp. 53–60. A very useful review of most of the literature on the subject is to be found in *Kition* III, pp. 103–126, which includes a discussion of O. Masson and M. Sznycer's article on the subject in *Recherches sur les Phéniciens à Chypre*, Paris, 1972, pp. 21–68.

⁷ Healey (above, n. 6), p. 56.

⁸ As Peckham suggests (above, n. 6).

⁹ For the use of ל- as 'to, for', see the standard dictionaries and grammars. For חרש as a craftsman, see Kition inscription 86A (above, n. 6). For חרש as an artisan using bellows, see Isa. 54:16. See also Z. Harris: *A Grammar of the Phoenician Language*, New Haven, 1936, p. 87; *DISO*, p. 97; M. Sznycer: Une inscription punique trouvée à Monte Sirai (Sardaigne), *Semitica* 15 (1965), pp. 38–43. For artisans' guilds, see I. Mendelsohn: Guilds in Ancient Palestine, *BASOR* 80 (1940), pp. 17–21. Especially significant is the use of the plural for the members of a guild, e.g. בני-הנביאים, 2 Kings 2:3, 5 (*ibid.*, p. 18). For the Persian period, see e.g. Neh. 3:31. It seems that in Phoenician the term נסכ was used for metal-casters and for artisans generally and metal-workers specifically; see M. Heltzer: A Recently Discovered Phoenician Inscription, *Atti del I congresso internazionale di studi fenici e punic*, Rome, 1983, pp. 119–123, where the author argues for הנסכ as a member of the Phoenician guild of metal-casters which maintained the professional status they had since the days of Ugarit. At Ugarit they were part of the royal economy and received raw materials from the royal stores to which they subsequently delivered their finished product.

אש יתנו. Jussive imperfect plural, '(that) they shall give'.¹⁰ It seems that here the phrase parallels the Hebrew in meaning as it does in syntactical structure, e.g. כי יתנו, אשר יתנו, שיחנו.

אגנ. As a bowl or container usually made of metal, this word is known in Akkadian¹¹ and Ugaritic;¹² in these languages אגנ refers to a large vessel. This is not always the case in the Bible, e.g. Song of Songs 7:2 (MT 7:3), Isa. 22:24, where אגנ means a small vessel.¹³ However, in Exod. 24:6 (MT 24:7) the plural אגנות seems to mean large basins, as it does in the Arad ostraca.¹⁴ In Phoenician אגנ is found at Kition.¹⁵

Line 2. כבד is known from Phoenician inscriptions as a verb meaning 'to honour, respect'. In Punic, as in Hebrew, it appears also as a noun, 'honour, glory'. Here it is probably an adjective, 'valuable'.¹⁶ It may conceivably be a *pi'el* plural from the verb כבד (Hebrew כָּבַד), with the translation '(and thus) honoured'.

של. An unknown personal name possibly originating from the root שאל with the *alef* contracted, similar to שלחאל from שאלחאל.¹⁷

על ('the overseer'). Its equivalent אשר על appears several times in the Bible, mainly in the title אשר על הכיית which also occurs on seals and sealings and on a tomb

For *bn hrš* as a member of such a guild, see M. Dietrich: *Die Keilalphabetischen Texte aus Ugarit*, Kevelaer, 1976, 4, 214, col. 2:15, p. 247. For the personal name בן חרש see CIS I, No. 637.

¹⁰ The pronoun אש or ש is usually equivalent to ש or אשר in the Bible (see below, nn. 19–22) and די in Aramaic. In the later books of the Bible אשר becomes a conjunction similar to כי (see the standard dictionaries, s.v.). For example of ש in the meaning of 'that, in order' see E. Ben-Yehudah: *A Complete Dictionary of Ancient and Modern Hebrew*, XVI, New York, 1959, p. 7511. See also Harris (above, n. 9), pp. 82, 108; J. Friedrich and W. Röllig: *Phönizisch-Punische Grammatik*, Rome, 1970, p. 121; *DISO*, p. 113. For the imperfect in Phoenician expressing a definite command, see Segert (above, n. 5), p. 194.

¹¹ For Akkadian *agannu*, which is usually of metal including silver, see CAD A/I, 1, p. 143; see also A. Salonen: *Die Hausgeräte des alten Mesopotamien nach sumerisch-akkadischen Quellen*, Helsinki, 1965, pp. 91–94.

¹² For Ugaritic, see C.H. Gordon: *Ugaritic Textbook*, Rome, 1965, p. 351, n. 65. In all likelihood 'gn appears in Phoenician in Ugaritic script on a cultic ewer from Sarepta, D.I. Owen in J. Pritchard: *Sarepta*, Philadelphia, 1975, pp. 102–104.

¹³ For a full discussion of אגנ, mainly as a large cultic vessel, sometimes inscribed with a dedication to a deity, see M. Pope: *The Song of Songs* (Anchor Bible), Garden City, 1977, p. 618.

¹⁴ Y. Aharoni: *Arad Inscriptions*, Jerusalem, 1981, pp. 12–14.

¹⁵ *Kition* III, p. 169.

¹⁶ *KAI*, No. 161, line 5; *DISO*, p. 11; R.S. Tombaek: *A Comparative Semitic Lexicon of the Phoenician and Punic Languages*, Missoula, 1978, pp. 136–177; F. Brown, S.R. Driver and C.A. Briggs: *A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament*, Oxford, 1955, p. 457, in Hebrew as an adjective כבדה, 'magnificent'; M. Jastrow: *Dictionary of Talmud Babli, Yerushalmi, Midrashic Literature and Targumim*, New York, 1950, p. 607.

¹⁷ The name סלח appears in Punic; N. Slouschz: *Thesaurus of Phoenician Inscriptions*, Tel Aviv, 1942, No. 572 (Hebrew); see also *KAI*, No. 65a. For the interchange of ש and ס in personal names, see F.L. Benz: *Personal Names in the Phoenician-Punic Inscriptions*, Rome, 1972, p. 204. For the loss of א in Phoenician and Punic, see Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), Nos. 14, 29. The name שאל is found in the Kilamuwa inscription; *KAI*, No. 24.

inscription.¹⁸ **על המס** or **אשר על המס** is part of the titles **על המלאכה** and **אשר על**,¹⁹ 'who is over (in charge of) the corvée', the latter occurring also on a seal.²⁰ **אשר על** usually refers to a very high official, a minister or royal steward, for example **אשר שבו** (Isa. 22:15), whose name probably appears on a stone panel in a tomb in Jerusalem, **על הבית** (שבו) **יהו אשר על הבית**.²¹ In Phoenician, **אש על שד כש** is possibly a high-ranking officer in Psammetichus' or Amosis' army.²² The Kition tariff inscription (see above, n. 6) has **על דל**, the guardians of the gate of the temple.²³ In the Piraeus inscription the overseer of the temple is referred to as **על בת אלמ**.²⁴ In Punic, **אש על המקדש** is the overseer of the temples.²⁵

אשרת. The singular feminine noun here probably means a shrine or temple.²⁶ At 'Akko, where a shrine probably stood adjacent to the find spot of the ostrakon, such a meaning seems certain. In Phoenician **אשרת** as a shrine or temple of the god of Hamon appears in the Ma'sub inscription.²⁷ In the masculine form **אשר** it occurs in the bilingual inscription from Pyrgi²⁸ and in Punic as **אשר הקרש**,²⁹ and lately possibly in this meaning in Hebrew in the Kuntillet 'Ajrud inscription.³⁰ In all these cases the shrine is linked to the name of a god or goddess. The absence of the name of a deity may indicate that here several shrines are referred to.

The continuation of the text testifies to the large amount of objects brought to a place which must have been a well-established shrine.

גלנמ. This word begins the enumeration of these objects. This noun, like others

¹⁸ Gen. 44: 1; 1 Kings 4:6, 16:9, 18:3; 2 Kings 15:5, 18:18, 19:2; Isa. 22:15, 36:3; S.H. Hooke: A Scarab and Sealing from Tell Duweir, *PEFQS* (1935), pp. 195–196; N. Avigad: A Group of Hebrew Seals from the Hecht Collection, *Festschrift Rëuben Hecht*, Jerusalem, 1979, pp. 119–120; idem, The Epitaph of a Royal Steward from Siloam Village, *IEJ* 3 (1953), pp. 137–152.

¹⁹ 1 Kings 9:23, in the plural as a group of officials.

²⁰ 2 Sam. 20:24; 1 Kings 4:6, 5:14, 12:18; 2 Chron. 10:18; N. Avigad: The Chief of the Corvée, *IEJ* 30 (1980), pp. 170–173. The simpler form **על הבית** (1 Kings 4:6) corresponds to the term *'l bt* in Ugaritic; R.M. Good: The Israelite Royal Steward in the Light of Ugaritic *'l bt*, *RB* 86 (1979), pp. 580–582. This early form also appears in the Bible in the same context in **על המס, על הנצבים, על הצבא**. See also below, n. 25.

²¹ Avigad (above, n. 18), *Festschrift Hecht*.

²² *CIS* I, No. 112; Slouschz (above, n. 17), p. 54.

²³ I accept Healey's reading of **דל** as 'gate' in this inscription, but I prefer to translate the phrase not 'who watched by the gate' but 'who are the overseers (or guardians) of the gate'.

²⁴ *KAI*, No. 60.

²⁵ *KAI*, No. 80.

²⁶ G.A. Cooke: *A Textbook of North Semitic Inscriptions*, Oxford, 1903, p. 50; *DISO*, p. 28.

²⁷ *KAI*, No. 19; II, p. 28 for **אשרת** and the Akkadian and Ugaritic occurrences.

²⁸ *KAI*, No. 277; J.A. Fitzmyer: The Phoenician Inscription from Pyrgi, *JAOS* 86 (1966), pp. 288–297.

²⁹ E. Lipiński: Aṭirat in Ancient Arabia, in Babylon and in Ugaritic: Her Relation to the Moon-God and the Sun-Goddess, *Orientalia Lovaniensis Periodica* 3 (1972), pp. 101–119.

³⁰ Z. Meshel: *Kuntillet 'Ajrud: A Religious Centre from the Time of the Judean Monarchy on the Border of Sinai*, Israel Museum, Cat. No. 175, Jerusalem, 1978, pp. 9, 12. For a different view of the reading **אשרת** in this inscription, see M. Weinfeld: Kuntillet 'Ajrud Inscriptions and their Significance, *Studi epigrafici e linguistici* 1 (1984), pp. 121–130.

describing the objects appearing later in the inscription, is in the plural and has a number following it indicating the quantity. גלנמ is previously unknown in Phoenician; however, it must be cognate with the Hebrew גֶּלֶה and Ugaritic *gl*,³¹ in the meaning of a cup for oil(?) sometimes made of gold, and Akkadian *gūlu* (a container or a vessel sometimes made of copper or silver).³² The form גלנמ may be a plural augmented by *nun* like אלנמ.³³ This word may also be connected very tentatively to the Hebrew גֶּלֶם, 'mantle', Aramaic גלימא.³⁴ However, this meaning seems doubtful; since the objects brought to the temple were donated and most probably made by metal-workers, we prefer the translation 'metal cups'.

Line 3. ממלאמ is previously unknown in Phoenician. The root is certainly מלא, 'to fill' as in מלאח, a full, brimming pool. The *pu'al* plural participle ממלאם appears in the Bible as inlays or insets; here it may mean round ringstands.³⁵

פכשח. These objects appear in the highest number (70) in the inscription. The word is unknown in Semitic languages; it seems to be a Phoenician plural form of the Greek πτυχις, 'box'.³⁶ This type of vessel is well known from archaeological finds, both in pottery and in metal. From the talmudic usage of קופסא, the metathesized form of this word, we know that such vessels were used to store clothes and coins.³⁷

Line 4. אדרת, 'large', is an antonym of the adjective צערת, 'small', as in Line 7. אדר is well known in Ugaritic,³⁸ Hebrew,³⁹ Phoenician and Punic.⁴⁰

לפמ is unknown in Phoenician, the nearest root being לפ, לפא in Jewish Aramaic. According to the *Targum Pseudo-Jonathan* (Lev. 6:5), the meaning is chiefly 'to arrange in courses',⁴¹ but this would hardly make sense as a noun in our inscription. It

³¹ Zech. 4:3; Eccles. 12:6; cf. Brown, Driver, Briggs (above, n. 16), s.v. For Ugaritic *gl*, see Gordon (above, n. 12), p. 379, No. 575; J. Aistleitner: *Wörterbuch der Ugaritischen Sprache*, Berlin, 1963, p. 65, No. 645. It is interesting that γαυλός appears in the fifth century as a 'round Phoenician vessel'; T.F.R.G. Braun: *Cambridge Ancient History*, III, Part 3, Cambridge, 1982, p. 25.

³² CAD G, 129^a; Salonen (above, n. 11), pp. 96–97.

³³ Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), p. 115; Segert (above, n. 5), p. 112.

³⁴ Jastrow (above, n. 16), p. 221. It was loaned from Aramaic to the Neo-Babylonian *gulemu* in the same meaning.

³⁵ Song of Songs 5:12, 14.

³⁶ We may surmise that the letter ξ was transcribed as כש, though later the Latin name Felix has כס. However, the letters ש and ס are often interchanged (above, n. 17); see also Harris (above, n. 9), p. 22; Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), pp. 19–20.

³⁷ *Targum Pseudo-Jonathan*, Deut. 31:26; Mishnah, *Kelim* 15:7; S. Krauss: *Talmudische Archäologie*, I, Leipzig, 1912, p. 67.

³⁸ R.E. Whitaker: *A Concordance of the Ugaritic Literature*, Cambridge, Mass., 1972, p. 8.

³⁹ Jer. 14:3. The adjective אדר and its antonym זער are known in Hebrew both in prose and poetry.

⁴⁰ CIS I, No. 3914; Slouschz (above, n. 17), p. 137.

⁴¹ According to A.M. Honeyman: Two Contributions to Canaanite Toponymy, 2: 'Talpioth', *Journal of Theological Studies* 50 (1949), pp. 15–16, the root of חלפיות (courses of stones) is לפא; Jastrow (above, n. 16), p. 715.

may, however, be the Phoenician plural of the Greek *λοπάς* (flat dish, plate) or *λέβης* (kettle, cauldron), which in talmudic Hebrew and Aramaic became *אילפס*, *אלפס* or *לפס*, *לבס*.⁴² The suggested Phoenician version, which lacks the suffix *ס*-, probably had the same meaning as in Greek — generally a cooking vessel but sometimes a deep bowl made to be set on a stand. For an example of the lack of the Greek ending in Phoenician, compare the Greek *έλαιον* (oil), which in the Phoenician form becomes *אלי*.⁴³

Line 5. *לגממ*. The closest parallel to this word is the plural of *לגין*, well known in Aramaic and late Hebrew as a term for a wine flask or water decanter; its origin is the Greek *λάβυνος* (flask, flagon).⁴⁴ It seems that in the plural *לגמ* became *לגממ*, either through a scribal error or because of assimilation of the *nun* to the *mem* of the plural.⁴⁵

Line 6. *מיפח* must be from the root *יפח*, *נפח*, which defines the metal-worker. The noun therefore refers to vessels made by the blowing and hammering technique and not by casting, *נסכ*. The singular would be *מיפח*. In Ugaritic the dual means ‘bellows’, as does the singular *מפוח* in Hebrew. The *yod* after the *mem* may appear as early as the fifth century B.C.E. and represents a diphthong or a long vowel, e.g. *מיקדש* = *מקדש*.⁴⁶

Line 7. *דקרת*. If the first letter is *bet*, i.e. *בקר*, these are cattle or heifers which were presumably brought for sacrifice. The closest form in the feminine is found in Jewish Aramaic in Palestine — *בקר*.⁴⁷ However, if we read the first letter as *dalet*, as I prefer, the word is *דקרת*, meaning deep copper bowls, as in Ugaritic⁴⁸ and Akkadian.⁴⁹

⁴² For *λοπάς* as a loan word appearing in many variants in late Hebrew and Aramaic, see S. Krauss: *Griechische und lateinische Lehnwörter im Talmud, Midrasch und Targum*, II, Berlin, 1899, p. 318. For different forms of this vessel, usually made, according to the talmudic sources, from clay, see Y. Brand: *Ceramics in Talmudic Literature*, Jerusalem, 1953, pp. 13–24 (Hebrew). The *אילפס*, for example, had a lid and was used specifically for boiling. The Greek *λοπάς* was made both of clay and copper; H. Blümner: *Die römischen Privataltertümer*³, Munich, 1911, p. 156; E. Guhl and W. Koner: *Das Leben der Griechen und Römer*, Berlin, 1876, p. 450; G.M.A. Richter and M.Y. Milne: *Shapes and Names of Athenian Vases*, New York, 1935, pp. 9–10, Figs. 69–71; *Function and Design in the Talmudic Period*, Haaretz Museum, Tel Aviv, 1978, p. 60 (Hebrew). For the loss of Greek morphological elements in Phoenician, see *DISO*, p. 237; Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), p. 102; J.K. Stark: *Personal Names in Palmyrene Inscriptions*, Oxford, 1971, p. 137.

⁴³ E. Puech in J. Briend and J.B. Humbert: *Tell Keisan*, Paris, 1980, pp. 303–304.

⁴⁴ Krauss (above, n. 42), pp. 305–306; Brand (above, n. 42), pp. 251–258.

⁴⁵ For the assimilation of *nun* in Phoenician to the following consonant, see Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), p. 21; Harris (above, n. 9), p. 28.

⁴⁶ For *mph* in Ugaritic, see Dietrich (above, n. 9), 1.4.1; G. del Olmo Lete (ed.): *Mitos y leyendas de Canaan según la tradición de Ugarit*, Madrid, 1981, p. 193; Friedrich and Röllig (above, n. 10), p. 42.

⁴⁷ In Targumic Aramaic *בקר* is used for young cattle.

⁴⁸ Gordon (above, n. 12), p. 385, No. 66.

⁴⁹ For the Akkadian *diqāru*, see *CAD D*, pp. 157–159 as bowls made of clay, stone or metal. See also *diqārū šehrū*, ‘small bowls’; Salonen (above, n. 11), p. 72 (Hebrew and Aramaic).

PALEOGRAPHY

Almost all the letters of the alphabet appear in the inscription, with the exception of *he*, *zayin*, *ṣet* and *samekh*. Most of the letters appear more than once and many of them show some variations. Their height ranges between 3 and 12 mm. There seems to be no significant difference between the forms of the letters on the two sides of the sherd, though some on the outside, like *ṣade* and *qof*, seem to be executed with special care. However, parts of more letters have peeled off on the outside than on the inside, and more letters are faded on the inside than on the outside of the sherd. The letters towards the end of the first line, especially the last two, are more congested and shorter than the others. Apparently the scribe found it difficult to write these letters on the bulging lower part of the rim.

Alef appears six times. The letters are similar to one another: a slightly slanting curved shaft with a stroke across the upper part of the shaft and the parallel lower stroke always attached to the shaft. This form is very similar to that on Ostrakon A at Sidon⁵⁰ and those from Elephantine.⁵¹

Bet appears four times, though the last one, in Line 7, may be a *dalet*. Its stance is generally bent to the right. The first *bet* (the first letter of the inscription) is attached to the next letter (*dalet*) by its upper part; since a fragment of ink has peeled off, the *bet* looks rather unusual. There are parallels to the 'Akko *bets* in some of the Sidon variations⁵² and in the tariff from Kition;⁵³ the closest parallels, however, are with the Elephantine ostraca.⁵⁴

Gimel appears three times. It twice has the usual form with the right leg thicker and longer than the left; the *gimel* in the first line is a shorter, equilateral version, probably executed in this way because of lack of space towards the end of the first line. The standard form has parallels at Kition⁵⁵ and especially in the Elephantine ostraca.⁵⁶

Dalet appears three or four times and is drawn similarly to *bet* with a short shaft. The form of the first *dalet* (in the first word) could be established only after its detachment from the preceding *bet*. Several variants of this form are found at Kition⁵⁷ and Sidon,⁵⁸ but the closest parallels are to be found in the Elephantine ostraca, where a variety of stances of *dalet* occur.⁵⁹

⁵⁰ Vanel, Table 1A.

⁵¹ Lidzbarski, No. 44.

⁵² Vanel, Table IB, especially the first and the last examples.

⁵³ CIS I, No. 86A. The references to CIS I, No. 86A, B are to the new photographs published in Peckham (above, n. 6), Pl. XV:1, 3 and also used in his book quoted in n. 2.

⁵⁴ Lidzbarski, Nos. 4, 8, 49.

⁵⁵ CIS I, No. 86A, B.

⁵⁶ Lidzbarski, No. 2.

⁵⁷ CIS I, No. 86A.

⁵⁸ Vanel, Table IE.

⁵⁹ Lidzbarski, No. 17 and especially No. 29, drawn in a manner very similar to our first *dalet*, with what may be a small depression on its head. On the other hand, this might have been the result of a fragment of ink peeling off. Neither this letter nor the *dalet* in the second line, which is similarly drawn, could be *ayin*, as suggested orally by Prof. F.M. Cross.

Waw, which appears six times, is very distinctive, with an arch-like curved head joining the top of the shaft from the left. In the last two examples this hook becomes almost a saddle-like feature on the top of the shaft (once leaning to the left), reminiscent of an early Karatepe *waw*. There are affinities to the first variation at Kition and mainly at Elephantine⁶⁰ and to the second in the Mit Rahine ostracon.⁶¹

Het, which appears twice, is of the bold well-developed type without a trace of horizontal bars. The first variant has three vertical, slightly curved strokes with the middle one touching the outer ones; its closest parallel is in the Elephantine ostraca.⁶² The other example has three completely free strokes; the closest comparisons are again from Kition and Elephantine.⁶³

Yod appears twice; both variants have the late horizontal form which is somewhat similar to the Kition examples,⁶⁴ though the parallels are even closer to the Elephantine ostraca.⁶⁵

Kaf appears in two variations, both with a straight shaft leaning to the right. The first, which is shorter, has its head bent up at a sharp angle to the top of the shaft; parallel forms appear at Elephantine.⁶⁶ The second *kaf* has a taller shaft with traces of what may possibly be a pronged end to the head, though a sharp bend downwards is more probable. If it does bend, it is somewhat similar to the *kaf* in the Eshmun'azor inscription⁶⁷ and a fourth-century example from Kition.⁶⁸

Lamed appears eight times and consists of a leftward leaning, sometimes slightly bent shaft, a very short horizontal foot and a downward curved tick on its end. A rare parallel in this period comes from Elephantine.⁶⁹ *Lamed* with such a tick is generally later and more characteristic of the Punic script.

Mem also appears eight times and it shows some variants, the body being differently curved. The central line, varying from almost horizontal to almost vertical, is drawn in one fairly long stroke. The closest parallels are at Kition⁷⁰ and Elephantine.⁷¹

Nun displays two variants in its four occurrences. The first, which retains a shoulder (the remains of a vertical top and a horizontal base line), is related to *nuns* with a sharply bent shoulder, for example those of the Saqqara papyri.⁷² The second variant is an

⁶⁰ Lidzbarski, Nos. 11, 26; the other type is exemplified in No. 34c.

⁶¹ N. Aimé-Giron: *Textes araméens d'Égypte*, Cairo, 1931, Pl. I:1; cf. Peckham (above, n. 2), p. 128.

⁶² Lidzbarski, Nos. 14a, 21.

⁶³ *CIS* I, No. 87; Lidzbarski, Nos. 2, 16.

⁶⁴ *CIS* I, Nos. 86A, B.

⁶⁵ Lidzbarski, Nos. 3, 9, 33a, 52, 54.

⁶⁶ Lidzbarski, Nos. 44, 54.

⁶⁷ Peckham (above, n. 2), Pl. V:7, 8a.

⁶⁸ *CIS* I, No. 50.

⁶⁹ Lidzbarski, No. 25.

⁷⁰ *CIS* I, No. 87.

⁷¹ Lidzbarski, Nos. 15c, 33a.

⁷² N. Aimé-Giron: Ba'al Saphon et les dieux de Tahpanhes dans un nouveau papyrus phénicien, *Annales du Service des Antiquités de l'Égypte* 40 (1940), Pl. 40.

almost straight thick or thin line with a slightly thickened top. Both variants also appear at Elephantine.⁷³

'Ayin appears twice; its distinctive character leaves no doubt as to its identification. The letter has a very prominent V-shaped form comprised of two strokes. The top of the *'ayin* is open in some occurrences of the cursive script from c. 500 B.C.E. onwards. However, even the closest parallels, such as the Elephantine ostraca⁷⁴ or the papyrus published by Aimé-Giron,⁷⁵ do not have the pronounced form of the examples in our ostrakon.

Pe appears twice or three times (that in Line 4 is uncertain). Both the certain *pes* lean to the right; the taller one with a small triangular head has a good parallel in Elephantine,⁷⁶ as does the shorter example with the head up.⁷⁷ The probable *pe* in Line 4 leans unusually to the left; the only parallel is at Sidon.⁷⁸ The alternate reading for this letter, *resh*, is less convincing.

Ṣade. In its only appearance, this letter has a well-drawn and regular shape; the top of the shaft and the top of the head are of the same height. It is closely paralleled in inscriptions from Sidon⁷⁹ and to some extent in the Elephantine ostraca, where the *ṣade* is shorter and broader.⁸⁰

Qof. This solitary letter at 'Akko has a very interesting shape; it is comprised of a small shaft and a partly enclosing right loop, the left one being already lost. This seems to be the result of the tendency seen in the Kition inscription⁸¹ and at Elephantine, where *qof* sometimes retains only its right loop.⁸²

Resh occurs five times. Three of the letters lean slightly to the left and have a rounded head; two have a vertical stance and a horizontal, angular head. The first type is well attested at Elephantine.⁸³ The angular-headed *resh* is known at Sidon, though there the shaft tends to be curved.⁸⁴

Shin. There are two types among the six *shins* in the inscription. Three times the letter appears in the sawtoothed 'archaizing' form well known at Elephantine.⁸⁵ Two or possibly three examples are letters with the ink partly splashed and partly peeled off;

⁷³ Lidzbarski, Nos. 2, 8, 9, 15c, 44.

⁷⁴ Lidzbarski, Nos. 4, 8, 11, 13, 14b, 15c, 41.

⁷⁵ N. Aimé-Giron: *Adversaria Semitica I*, *Bulletin de l'Institut Français d'Archéologie Orientale* 38 (1939), Pl. I:1.

⁷⁶ Lidzbarski, No. 11a.

⁷⁷ Lidzbarski, Nos. 25, 34, 47.

⁷⁸ Vanel, Table 1A.

⁷⁹ The inscription of Tabnit, *KAI*, No. 13, and Bod'astart, *KAI*, No. 15.

⁸⁰ Lidzbarski, Nos. 34c, 48.

⁸¹ *CIS I*, No. 86A.

⁸² Lidzbarski, Nos. 4, 50. It seems that in 'Akko we have the earliest representation of *qof* with the head separated from the shaft.

⁸³ Lidzbarski, Nos. 13, 33a, 40.

⁸⁴ Vanel, Table 1A.

⁸⁵ Lidzbarski, Nos. 7, 27, 37.

they belong to the three-pronged variant, early examples of which are known at Ipsambul⁸⁶ and mainly at Elephantine.⁸⁷

Taw appears eight times. It has a quite uniform stance tilted to the right on an almost straight shaft, with the crossbar drawn from the top of the shaft or near it almost vertically to the right. The closest parallels are at Elephantine.⁸⁸

CONCLUSIONS

The inscription provides evidence for the existence of a Phoenician temple at 'Akko. The appearance of the inscription and its well-drawn script confirm that this was an order, possibly a copy, issued by a high authority, perhaps even from the office of the governor of the city. According to this order, the guild of metal-workers is to give the man in charge of the temple (or temples) a precious basin; it is also ordered to donate other metal vessels, some of which were probably of precious metals. We have here the first written evidence for a Phoenician cult at 'Akko and a fleeting glimpse of the political and socio-economic aspects of the life of the city.

The inscription was found in a structure that was probably used for administrative and storage purposes. Nearby, a well-constructed wall uncovered in the early seasons of excavation is apparently all that remains of the Phoenician temple itself. Of particular importance in this connection are the artifacts of cultic character found in the pit with the ostrakon and in the neighbouring area in the Persian period stratum; zoomorphic and anthropomorphic male and female figurines, feet of broken statues and the lower part of a seated goddess inscribed with Cypriote syllabary (?) signs.

The inscription enriches our knowledge of the Phoenician language, its vocabulary and its syntax. In addition to the new expressions of clear Semitic origin, a number of Phoenician words seemingly of foreign provenance appear here for the first time. Although the origin of some of these is not yet certain, if I am correct in my interpretation the ostrakon contains the earliest known evidence of Greek words entering Phoenician.⁸⁹

As regards the date of the ostrakon, it undoubtedly belongs to the period of Persian rule. The pit in which it was found yielded only finds from this period. The paleographic analysis points to the fifth century B.C.E., more specifically to the first half of that century and probably to its early part. In paleographic terms it is closest to the

⁸⁶ *CIS I*, No. 111.

⁸⁷ Lidzbarski, Nos. 7, 23, 52, 58.

⁸⁸ Lidzbarski, Nos. 12, 27, 30, 59.

⁸⁹ For the introduction of Greek words into West Semitic languages, see A. Montgomery: *Interpreters' Critical Commentary: Daniel*, Edinburgh, 1922, p. 22. It is probable that the entry was made much earlier than the third century B.C.E.; see Braun (above, n. 31), pp. 24–27. For δαεικός = דרכנס and δαεικός = דרכנס in the Piraeus inscription, see *KAI II*, p. 74.

Phoenician inscriptions of the fifth century on the pottery vessels found at Elephantine. After the campaign of Cambyses against Egypt in 526 B.C.E., 'Akko became an important military, economic and administrative centre either as an independent city or as part of the Tyrian Kingdom and continued to be so during the entire Persian period.⁹⁰ By then the Phoenician fleet and the Greek mercenaries in the eastern Mediterranean were an indispensable factor in the Persian empire.⁹¹ We may ascribe the Greek elements in the inscription to the flourishing trade carried out by Phoenician 'Akko with the Greek world.⁹² On the other hand, the wine or oil jars inscribed in Phoenician found at Elephantine must have come from a territory where Phoenician was written and which was rich in oil and wine. Such a territory might have been in southern Phoenicia, western Galilee as far as the Carmel ridge; its capital 'Akḥ served by then as the main port for the maritime trade between southern Phoenicia and Egypt. It is therefore significant that the script of 'Akko, but for a few letters, shows a tradition similar to that of many of the Elephantine ostraca. It may be that some of the wine or oil jars found at Elephantine came to Egypt from the territory of 'Akko.⁹³

Until the current excavations the main evidence about 'Akko of the Persian period came from fragmentary mentions by Greek writers and from scanty archaeological finds. This first substantial inscription in Phoenician from 'Akko is a significant addition

⁹⁰ Strabo, *Geography*, XVI, 2, 25–26; Diodorus Siculus, XV, 41, 3. There is no definite evidence for 'Akko's being an independent city within the frame of the satrapy of Ebir nari, though it certainly was a royal fortress. There are two schools of thought in this matter: one represented by Kahrstedt, for whom 'Akko formed part of the kingdom of Tyre, the other represented by Leutze and Galling, which speaks for 'Akko's independence. There is meagre evidence for both sides; the lack of 'Akko's own coinage in the Persian period seems to add weight to the view that even though the city was an important one it may still have been dependent on Tyre; see *PRWE*, 1959, cols. 1883–1886, s.v. Ptolemais.

⁹¹ Herodotus, *Historiae*, III, 19; VII, 89–99.

⁹² Large amounts of Aegean pottery, at first East Greek and later Attic, as well as of other provenance, found from Al-Mina on the Syrian coast to Meşad Ḥashavyahu and Ashdod on the southern Palestinian coast attest to the scope of the Greek trade with Phoenicia and Philistia, if not necessarily to Greek colonization.

⁹³ As noted above, some of the letters of our ostrakon demonstrate a link with letters at Saqqara. Is it pure coincidence that an 'Aki (a man from 'Akko) appears in the more or less contemporary ostraca from Saqqara (Aimé-Giron [above, n. 75], pp. 18, 19) and Memphis (P. Magnanini: *Le iscrizioni fenici de Oriente*, Rome, 1973, p. 69) and in one of the fourth-century B.C.E. inscriptions at Abydos? (*CIS I*, Nos. 99–100; M. Lidzbarski: *Ephemeris für semitische Epigraphik*, III, Giessen, 1915, p. 27). In Lidzbarski, p. 20, the author suggests that the wine jars were sent from Phoenicia to the Phoenician colony in Memphis and later distributed to places like Elephantine. For the people of 'Akko in the Persian period, see also M. Heltzer: *The People of Accho in Phoenician and Punic Documents*, in *Festschrift Hecht* (above, n. 18), pp. 142–143. It is still too early to fix exactly the absolute chronology of the early Persian stratum at 'Akko (4b) where our ostrakon was found. This stratum could not, however, end later than in 390 B.C.E., with the conquest of the coast by the Cypriote Evagoras and the Egyptian Akhoris; a stone altar base bearing the latter's name was found at 'Akko. The next Persian stratum in 'Akko starts most probably, both on the mound and in the lower city, with Pharnabazos who reconquered the coast in c. 380 B.C.E. (Diodorus Siculus, XV, 41). This date may serve as the *terminus ad quem*, therefore, for the ostrakon from 'Akko.

to Phoenician epigraphy and paleography. It throws light on some aspects of their society, cult and temple economy. The evidence from 'Akko may also serve as a paradigm for other cities in southern Phoenicia in the early Persian period.⁹⁴

⁹⁴ These cities are mentioned in the two main sources for the coastal cities of Palestine in the Persian period, the Eshmun'azor inscription and the Periplus of Pseudo-Scylax. The cities are Ecdippa (Akhzib), Ake ('Akko), Hepha (Haifa), Sycamimon polis (Shiqmona), Adaros, Doros (Dor), Krokodeilon polis (Crocodilopolis), Jope (Jaffa), Ascalon; K. Galling: *Die syrisch-palästinische Küste nach der Beschreibung bei Pseudo-Skylax*, *ZDPV* 61 (1938), pp. 66–90; M. Avi-Yonah: *The Holy Land from the Persian to the Arab Conquests (536 B.C. to A.D. 640)*, Grand Rapids, 1966, pp. 28–31.



A: The outside of the sherd (Lines 1-4).



B: The inside of the sherd (Lines 5-7).

PHOENICIAN INSCRIPTION FROM 'AKKO

C-D: Impressions
of Seals C and D,
twice actual size.



A GROUP OF PHOENICIAN CITY SEALS